

The First \$500 Buffer Worksheet

*The complete tool from **Your First \$500 Buffer** by Simon Gebhart.*

Everything above explains *why*. This is *how*, laid out as a one-page worksheet. If you skipped straight here, you have everything you need — fill it in and you're running the full plan.

Part 1 — The Target Calculator

Your goal is \$500. Split it across your paydays between now and your target date. There's a bare-minimum column and a stretch column — pick whichever one you can actually sustain, not the one that sounds impressive.

Step 1: How often do you get paid?

- ☐ Weekly (52 paydays/year)
- ☐ Biweekly (26 paydays/year)
- ☐ Semi-monthly (24 paydays/year)
- ☐ Monthly (12 paydays/year)

Step 2: Pick a timeline and find your per-paycheck number.

Target timeline	Weekly	Biweekly	Semi-monthly	Monthly
Bare-minimum — 6 months	\$19	\$38	\$42	\$84
Standard — 3 months	\$38	\$77	\$83	\$167
Stretch — 6 weeks	\$84	\$167	—	—

(These are \$500 divided evenly across paydays in that window. Round to whatever's easiest to automate — \$20 instead of \$19, \$40 instead of \$38.)

Step 3: Write your number.

My pay frequency: _____

My per-paycheck amount: \$_____

My target date to hit \$500 at this pace: _____

If even the bare-minimum column feels like too much right now, don't wait for a "better" month. Automate \$5 or \$10 per paycheck today. The mechanism — automation over willpower — matters more than the size of the first transfer. You can raise the amount later without ever having to "decide to start saving" again, because you'll have already started.

Part 2 — The Automation Script

This is the exact sequence from the previous chapter, laid out as steps. Do this in one sitting — it takes under ten minutes.

1. **Check which option you have.** Log into your employer's payroll portal or ask HR: "Can I split my direct deposit between two accounts, or send a fixed dollar amount to savings?" If yes, go to step 2. If no, skip to step 4.
2. **If split deposit is available:** open the direct deposit form, add your savings account's routing and account number, and set it to a **flat dollar amount** (not a percentage) matching what you wrote in Part 1.
3. **Confirm the split.** Most portals show a preview before your next pay run — check that checking still gets the remainder and savings gets your target amount. Save/submit.
4. **If split deposit isn't available:** open your bank's app, go to "Transfers" or "Recurring Transfers," and set up an automatic transfer from checking to savings.
5. **Set the transfer date to your payday,** not a few days after. The RCT didn't test this exact timing, but the same logic applies: money you've already moved isn't money you can talk yourself out of.
6. **Set the amount** to what you wrote in Part 1.
7. **Name the savings account something that isn't neutral** — "Buffer," "\$500 Fund," "Don't Touch." A one-word label does real work at 11 p.m. when you're tempted to move it back.
8. **Screenshot or write down the confirmation.** This is your proof the automation exists — check it in 30 days, not your willpower.

If you can't do split deposit or an automatic transfer today for any reason, the fallback is a recurring calendar reminder with the same dollar amount and the same day. Be honest with yourself about what it is: even the study's "active choice" arm — a one-time forced yes-or-no decision, which is a stronger push than any passive reminder — moved participation no more than 5 points, versus the 40-plus-point jumps true automation produced. A reminder is weaker still. But it beats doing nothing while you sort out the automated option.

Part 3 — The Stop-and-Redirect Rule

The day your balance hits \$500, don't let the automation quietly keep going into a fund that's already served its purpose without a plan for what's next.

When you hit \$500, do one of these two things — same day:

1. **If you have any debt with an interest rate above ~10%** (most credit cards, some personal loans): redirect the automated transfer to extra debt payments instead of savings. Keep the \$500 buffer intact and untouched — it's still doing its job — but stop growing it further until high-interest debt is handled. You're not removing the buffer; you're pointing the *automation* at the next problem.
2. **If you have no high-interest debt,** or once it's cleared: keep the exact same automation running, aimed at the next tier — \$750, then working toward \$2,000. You don't need a new decision or a new system. Same transfer, same day, same amount (or raise it by \$5-10 per paycheck once \$500 is behind you).

Either way, the mechanism doesn't change. You're not starting over. You're redirecting a system that's already proven it works.

Do this now: Fill in your worksheet above — your pay frequency, your per-paycheck amount, and the date you expect to cross \$500 at that pace. Put the date somewhere you'll actually see it: phone lock screen note, calendar entry, sticky note on your card.

The full guide: amazon.com/dp/BOH7JQ5WFF